

Nick Heindl

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Technical Designer and Accessibility Champion

Principal Technical Designer, Accessibility Team Lead, Gameplay Engineer. Titles be damned, Nick specializes in making memorable experiences by solving complex technical and people problems.

Nick has an infectious passion for tech design, accessibility, and narrative. He thrives when learning new technologies and collaborating with different roles to empower teams to do their best work.

“Force Multiplier”, “Mentor”, “Advocate” - all terms used by previous leads to describe Nick’s impact.

Selected Development Experience

That’s No Moon

Crossfire

Senior Technical Designer

May 2026 - Present

Part of Gameplay Systems and Mechanics team with a primary focus on 3Cs and supporting teams.

- Primary Tools: Unreal Engine 5, Blueprint Scripting, C++, p4
- UE5 Systems/Tools used: Gameplay Ability System, Cameras, Sequencer, Configs, Mutables

Eighth Lantern Studios

Toypunk

Technical Designer

November 2025 – May 2026

Owned and supported multiple features on a small team to bring a new title from concept to demo.

- Primary Tools: Unreal Engine 5, Blueprint Scripting, C++, git
- UE5 Systems/Tools used: EnhancedInput, Gameplay Ability System, Sequencer, Engine Version updating, Plugin Integration, git, State Machines, Data Tables

Kurts Squires (Personal Project)

Liveliest Catch

Technical Designer

October 2025 – May 2026

Created a “friendslop” crab fishing game in Fortnite using a heavily custom Verse-based architecture

- Primary Tools: Unreal Engine 5 for Fortnite (UEFN), Verse Scripting; Twine, Ink/Inky (prototyping)
- UE5/UEFN Systems/Tools used: Verse, Devices, Scenegraph, Level Editor, Asset Integration

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ZeniMax Online Studios (Xbox, Bethesda)

Unannounced AAA MMORPG

Accessibility Team Lead and Principal Technical Designer

July 2023 – October 2025

Senior Technical Designer

August 2021 – July 2023

Primary Tools: ECS-based engine, AngelScript, Blueprint-like Visual Scripting, C++, C#, Figma, Miro

Worked closely with users in all departments to empower them and maximize their efficiency

- Created script review process, established best practices, and documented workflows
- Wrote utility libraries, exemplar content, and development tutorials
- Collaborated with various teams to triage blockers early and ensure alignment
- Onboarded multiple tech designers, Mentored designers across departments

Embedded within Narrative and Cinematic teams to bolster features, processes, and pipelines

- Technical Product Owner of Narrative Systems from first implementation to alpha
- Led efforts to assess, prototype, and scale up narrative systems, including first examples of RPG Choice & Consequence and first complex scripted quest content

Partnered with various Gameplay teams to create and tune player-facing features

- Worked with 3Cs team to balance movement and camera to minimize Sim Sickness
- Joined Combat team to revamp Aim Assist systems and create live-edit tooling

Founded and led a multi-disciplinary Accessibility Team

- Responsible for working with every other team to define roadmaps, goals, and success to ensure we were on track to meet (and exceed) legal and publishing standards
- Ran workshops, presentations, 1-1s, and contributed to Xbox-wide talks and initiatives

Directly contributed to various accessibility features through design and implementation

- Improved accessibility of internal development tools
- Performed tech evaluations of third-party software (IRIS, Chroma, and more)
- Created a technical demo to showcase assistive devices and highlight our input system
- Implemented various standards for subtitles, captions, and text scaling across 4+ platforms

PUBG Corporation

PlayerUnknown's Battlegrounds (PUBG)

Gameplay Engineer

October 2020 – July 2021

Primary Tools: Unreal Engine, C++, PowerShell, git, p4

- Engineering feature owner for new vehicles as part of an unreleased map
- Polished a prototyped game mode launched as a limited time event
- Bolstered a new remote workflow for UE with git and p4 to support non-technical staff
- Assisted Tech Director with setting up a recruiting and interviewing process

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Raven Software (Activision Blizzard)

Call of Duty: Warzone, Call of Duty: Modern Warfare, Call of Duty: Cold War, Call of Duty: Black Ops III, Call of Duty: Online (China)

Gameplay Engineer

May 2016 – October 2020

Associate Gameplay Engineer

May 2016 – February 2018

Gameplay Engineer Intern

Summer 2015

Primary Tools: 3+ proprietary idTech-derived engines, C++, Custom Script Language (GSC), Lua, p4

- Led small team to design, architect, and implement Call of Duty Warzone's Ping Marker system
- Led refactor of single player campaign objectives to empower narrative designers
- Prototyped, polished, and shipped many features and game modes for a worldwide audience
- Built an in-game automated test tool to assist Design and QA on Call of Duty's first Battle Royale
- Designed & built player ranking system; Used live metrics to tune rewards
- Profiled code and established standards to reduce live service errors by tenfold
- Led two multidisciplinary teams in Activision-wide innovation competitions for Mobile
- Collaborated with worldwide teams to set up analytics design & instrumentation for Warzone
- Engineering mentor to interns, travelled with the University team to recruit at universities

Personal

- Regularly prototype workflows and ideas with Ink/Inky and Twine
- On Board of Directors for Wisconsin Games Alliance
- Actively coaching and mentoring students and presenting talks and panels to conferences
- Certified Accessible Player Experience Practitioner (CAPXP): accessible.games/apxp

Education

University of Wisconsin-Madison

Computer Sciences and Linguistics